

Cassia senna syn. *Senna alexandrina* (Fabaceae)

Senna, Alexandrian Senna

Almost everyone will have taken a preparation containing senna at some time in their lives. Senna is probably one of the best known herbal medicines, not least because it is still widely used in conventional medicine. It is a very efficient laxative and is a particularly useful remedy for the occasional bout of constipation. It has a slightly bitter, nauseating taste, and is therefore generally mixed with other herbs.



Senna shrubs have pairs of lance-shaped leaflets arranged on either side of a central stem.

Habitat & Cultivation

Senna is native to tropical Africa and is now cultivated throughout that continent. It is grown from seed in spring or from cuttings in early summer and requires plenty of sun. The leaves may be picked before or while the plant is in flower, and the pods are collected when they are ripe in autumn.

Related Species

There are over 400 species of *Cassia*. Tinnevely senna (*C. angustifolia*) is grown in the Indian subcontinent and has the same therapeutic properties as *C. senna*. In Ayurvedic medicine, it is used for skin problems, jaundice, bronchitis, and anemia, as well as for constipation. *Jue ming zi* (*C. obtusifolia*) is used in traditional Chinese medicine for "liver fire" patterns, constipation, and atherosclerosis.

Key Constituents

- Anthraquinone glycosides (sennosides)
- Naphthalene glycosides
- Mucilage

- Flavonoids
- Volatile oil

Key Actions

- Stimulant
- Laxative
- Cathartic

Research

- **Sennosides** Extensive research during the last 50 years has led to a clear understanding of senna's action. The sennosides irritate the lining of the large intestine, causing the muscles to contract strongly, resulting in a bowel movement about 10 hours after the dose is taken. The sennosides also stop fluid being absorbed from the large intestine, helping to keep the stool soft.

Traditional & Current Uses

- **Early records** The herb was first used medicinally by Arabian physicians in the 9th century CE.
- **Constipation** Senna has always been specifically used for constipation. It is particularly appropriate when a soft stool is required, for example in cases of anal fissure. Senna is a good short-term laxative but should not be taken for more than 10 days as this leads to weakening of the large intestine muscles.
- **Cathartic** As a cathartic (very strong laxative), senna can cause cramping and colic, and is therefore normally taken with aromatic, carminative herbs that relax the intestinal muscles.

Self-help Use

- **Constipation**, p. 307.



Senna

A small perennial shrub growing to 3 ft (1 m), with a straight, woody stem and yellow flowers.

Parts Used



Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** Do not give to children under 12. Do not take for more than 10 days at a time. Do not take if suffering from colitis. During pregnancy, take on advice of your health care practitioner.



Tablets are the standard senna preparation and are convenient. Take for occasional constipation.



Decoction For constipation, steep 3–6 senna pods and 1 g fresh ginger in $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) freshly boiled water for 6–12 hours. Strain and drink.



Infusion For mild constipation, infuse 1–2 senna pods, 1 g fresh ginger, and 1–2 cloves in $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) freshly boiled water for 15 minutes. Strain and drink.

🌿 **Tincture** is prescribed by herbalists to treat short-term constipation.